

>> Pakistan vs USA, Colombo

After the USA stunned Pakistan in a thrilling Super Over win in Dallas at the last T20 World Cup, all eyes will be on a repeat of this fixture in spin-dominant conditions at the SSC Ground in Colombo. Though a former champion and an overwhelming favourite on paper in this fixture, Pakistan has been susceptible to crumbling under pressure against weaker opponents in ICC events, as defeats against Zimbabwe (T20 World Cup 2022) and Afghanistan (ODI World Cup 2023) attest. Seniors in the team, such as Babar Azam, Fakhar Zaman and Shaheen Shah Afridi, will need to step up and ensure Pakistan does not slip to another ignominious defeat. The contest could be defined by how Pakistan's spinners, Abrar Ahmed, Mohammad Nawaz and Shadab Khan, perform against a USA line-up critically short of international game time in the shortest format. The USA has not played a single T20I match since April last year, while Pakistan has gone about its preparations with gusto; after the series against Australia, it will have played 47 matches since the showpiece in 2024, the most by an ICC Full Member.



A rematch loaded with memory: Pakistan meets the USA in Colombo, with spin and pressure likely to shape the contest. AFP

>> Afghanistan vs South Africa, Ahmedabad

Afghanistan's dream run at the T20 World Cup 2024 was snapped by South Africa in the semifinal, and the Rashid Khan-led side will have a score to settle against the Proteas at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad. South Africa is one of just three ICC Full Members, the others being India and England, which Afghanistan still has not been able to topple in the shortest format, and defying history will not be easy. The high-scoring venue will pose a daunting challenge for Afghanistan's spinners against a power-packed line-up, which includes the likes of Dewald Brevis, Tristan Stubbs and Ryan Rickelton. Rashid's familiarity with the conditions, owing to his four seasons and counting with Gujarat Titans in the Indian Premier League (IPL), will be a valuable resource for Afghanistan's spin unit. The batting, meanwhile, will have to contend with the pace and bounce of Marco Jansen, Kagiso Rabada and Anrich Nortje, the same pace troika that bowled out Afghanistan for 56 in the semifinal in Trinidad.



Litmus test: Afghanistan batters prepare for a daunting examination against South Africa's pace battery at a high-scoring Ahmedabad venue. GETTY IMAGES